

**State of Vermont
Secretary of State
Office of Professional Regulation
Board of Allied Mental Health**

In re: AMANDA GAUTREAUX

Docket No. 2026-134

License No. 068.0135938

**Appearances: For the State: Zoe Newman, Esq.
For the Respondent: Devin McKnight, Esq.**

Presiding Officer: George K. Belcher

Board Members Participating:

**Jessyca Nelle, Non-Licensed/Non-Certified Psychotherapist
Marjorie Trombly, LCMHC, Vice Chair
Lyn Turcotte, *ad hoc*, Public Member
Dana Poverman, *ad hoc*, Public Member**

Exhibits Admitted:

**State Exhibit 1; Stipulation and Consent Order dated 6/19/2023
State Exhibit 2: 51 page text message chain
Respondent Exhibit B: List of Respondent's Vermont Telehealth Clients**

SUMMARY SUSPENSION FINDINGS AND ORDER

This matter came before the Board of Allied Mental Health Practitioners on a Request for a Summary Suspension dated August 13, 2026. Notice of hearing was given by mail on August 13, 2026, and there were no objections as to notice. The hearing was held electronically on August 20, 2026, with the attorneys, the witnesses, and the Board members, all participating by telephone, in person, or via electronic means pursuant to the Office of Professional Regulation Rules.

Findings of Fact

Based on the evidence presented at the hearing, the Vermont Board of Allied Mental Health Practitioners finds as follows:

1. The Respondent is licensed in Vermont as a Licensed Mental Health Counselor (LCMHC). She resides in Troy, Maine. Her Vermont license was originally issued on June 10, 2024, and it expires on January 31, 2027.
2. The Respondent was previously rostered in Vermont as a Non-Licensed and Non-Certified Psychotherapist and that credential expired on November 30, 2024.
3. In 2022, the State charged the Respondent with unprofessional conduct in Docket Nos. 2022-262 and 2022-263. Those charges related to an inappropriate

texting relationship between the Respondent as a therapist and a 19-year-old client and a second inappropriate texting relationship with a second client.

4. The Respondent agreed to a stipulation and consent order. (State Exhibit 1) In that she admitted unprofessional conduct including: (1) performance of unsafe or unacceptable patient or client care; (2) entering into a additional relationship with a client that might impair the psychotherapist's objectivity; (3) failure to conform to the essential standards of acceptable and prevailing practice; (4) failure to maintain professional boundaries; and (5) failure to comply with provisions of state or federal statutes or rules governing the practice of the profession. (See State Exhibit 1) The stipulation established that the Respondent had breached boundaries with her client via text messages, including text messages outside of therapy sessions. In addition, the Respondent agreed that she had breached ethical boundaries by imposing on two clients "her own values, attitudes, beliefs and behaviors." (See paragraphs 59 and 60 of the Stipulation and Consent Order)
5. The Respondent was reprimanded and subjected to conditions for the period of one year. In July of 2024 the conditions were removed from the Respondent's license/credential.
6. In May of 2024 the Respondent began a treating relationship with a Client (S.B.) by tele-health, psychotherapy sessions. While the sessions were initially positive, the Respondent later began using her psychotherapy sessions with the Client to discuss the Respondent's personal life including fights with her boyfriend, a family member's medical needs, and the Respondent's sexual relationships.
7. A complaint was filed with the Office of Professional Regulation by a subsequent therapist of the Client. Investigator Ryan Prince was assigned to investigate the complaint. Investigator Prince interviewed the Respondent with her attorney present. Initially, when asked whether she used her personal phone (rather than her work phone) to communicate with the Client, the Respondent initially questioned whether she did. When confronted with a copy of a text chain which included communication from her personal phone, she admitted having used her personal phone to communicate with the Client at times.
8. When the Respondent was asked whether she had crossed boundaries with the Client, she admitted crossing boundaries in order to better therapeutically connect with the Client.
9. The Respondent communicated with the Client using her work phone. She also used her personal phone for both text communication and oral telephone conversations.
10. The therapist/client relationship started in May of 2024 with sessions approximately two times per week. There was a break in the treatment relationship while the Client was on an "IOP" (Intensive Outpatient Program) during which the Client was not authorized by the IOP program to use the Respondent as a second therapist. Despite this, the Client and the Respondent communicated during this time on a personal basis. When the IOP program concluded in December of 2025, the Client resumed treatment with the Respondent. It was shortly after this resumption that the Respondent began sharing her personal information with the Client. In January of 2026, the Respondent initiated texts to the Client on the Respondent's personal phone.
11. The Client began to feel uncomfortable with the communications with the Respondent in early 2026, in part, because the Respondent was communicating her own personal information about sex. The Client eventually stopped

communicating with the Respondent sometime toward the end of the month of February 2026. The therapist/client relationship continued and was not terminated by the Respondent listing the Client as inactive until early March 2026. The last communication from the Respondent to the Client was on March 1, 2026.

12. The Respondent never conducted a closure session with the Respondent. The Respondent produced no notes or records demonstrating closure of the relationship. The Respondent carried the Client as an active client during the full month of February 2026. This date is important since many of the documented communications which exceeded reasonable boundaries as set forth in State's Exhibit 2 occurred during the month of February 2026 and during the therapist/client relationship.
13. Although the Respondent communicated with the Client orally on the telephone, the clearest evidence of inappropriate communication is contained in State Exhibit 2 in which the Respondent communicated with the Client about the following personal information concerning the Respondent's life:
 - a. Car troubles and cost of repair (page 13-14)
 - b. Possible bankruptcy (page 15)
 - c. Breakup with boyfriend, "sobbing intermittently", questioning her own sanity (page 20-21)
 - d. Respondent "...feel[s] guilty for even sharing the way I do" (page 23)
 - e. Texting a photo of the Respondent's son sleeping in her bed (page 25)
 - f. "[The Client has been] one of my most consistent supports. I'm feeling terribly about that." (page 29)
 - g. "I just can't stop crying and thinking about being dead to be totally honest. I started taking a medication I had on hand because I can't take it anymore. And its not fair to you and anyone else." (page 32)
 - h. "I just had a complete meltdown over my dog. Way disproportionate to the event. I'm gonna actually take the day off and go back to sleep. I'm starting myself on some meds, too." (page 33)
 - i. "This will sound terrible, but I need the money. I'm struggling so hard with billing and making sure I'm getting paid. I have no idea if I'm getting what I'm supposed to and can't keep up with tracking it." (page 37)
 - j. "I feel terribly because I know that there's been a change in me since either Florida or the 276th breakup with [D] and I can't seem to get myself together .. I think I feel dry very much like you right now that idk wtf to say." (page 39)
 - k. "I want someone to hold me in bed" (page 41)
 - l. "I need to work on my self-esteem" (page 41)
 - m. "He broke up with me [...] Yes tonight [...] He kicked me out" (page 42)
 - n. "I'm sad. I'm tired. I'm frustrated. I'm hurt. I'm disgusted. I'm disappointed. I'm overwhelmed (page 45)
 - o. "'Retreat' It needs to happen [...] You, her, me and my other client fr Friend" (page 47)
 - p. "I've struggled with staying on top of notes the entirety of my time as a therapist. It's just gotten really bad now that I don't have oversight. If I am audited I'm ... well... I'll be busy forging documentation" (page 54)
 - q. "Can I ask you a favor? [...] Thanks. I'm a fucking mess. We've seen each other six times I need to get billing to CorVel. I haven't written a single

note. You think you can? Lol. Or even 6 topics I can expand on? I'm sorry. I don't know how I'm gonna get through my day" (page 56)

- r. "But truly, I think something in me while the bottom was dropping out of my personal life saw something in you that was safe. But that's not and never was your job. That's what makes me a shitty therapist here. I miss you and care very much about your wellbeing and all those beautiful girls. I'm very angry and disappointed with myself and that my lack of foresight has created a scenario where you feel like I can no longer support you...." (page 62)
14. The Respondent invited the Client to visit her at her home (which the Client did not accept).
 15. The Respondent testified that as a general rule she does not continue with personal relationships with former patients. This testimony was contradicted by references in the text-chain.
 16. The communications from the Respondent to the Client, at times, appeared to have caused the Client to worry about the physical and emotional health of the Respondent.
 17. The personal communications from the Respondent to the Client were not therapeutic in the opinion of the Client. The communications interfered with the Client "doing the work I needed to do."
 18. The behavior of the Respondent which was proven in this case show a severe disregard for professional boundaries which put into questions the ability of the Respondent to safely provide therapy to the public. The safety of the public health and welfare was proven to be at risk by the continued licensure of the Respondent. Emergency action is necessary to protect the public since members of the public, existing patients, new and potential patients, have no way of knowing of the Respondent's behavior in this case and her failure to follow basic rules and boundaries which are part of her profession.

Conclusions of Law

The findings of fact and conclusions of law set forth in this summary suspension order are for the purposes of this order only.

- (a) Where a regulatory Board finds that emergency action is necessary and imperative to protect the public health, safety, and/or welfare of the people of the State of Vermont, the Board may summarily suspend the license of a licensee pending a hearing on the merits. 3 VSA Sec. 814(c). Here, the Board so finds.
- (b) In this case, the proven facts disclose behavior by the Respondent which violates professional conduct statutes; 26 VSA Sec. 3271(a)(6) [entering into an additional relationship with a client that might impair the counselor's objectivity or otherwise interfere in the counselor's professional obligations]; 3 VSA Sec. 129(a)(28) [engaging in conduct of a character likely to deceive, defraud or harm the public]; 3 VSA Sec. 1291(b)(2) [failure to practice competently including failure to conform to the essential standards of acceptable and prevailing practice]; 3 VSA Sec. 129a(b)(1) [Failure to practice competently including unsafe or unacceptable patient or client care]; 3 VSA Sec. 129(a)(26) [Sexually harassing or exploiting a patient or client and failing to maintain professional boundaries]; and 3 VSA Sec. 129(a)(15) [failing to exercise independent professional judgment in the performance of licensed activities when that

judgment is necessary to avoid action repugnant to the obligations of the profession].

- (c) When a client entrusts their care, confidential information and deepest feelings to a therapist, it is reasonable for the client and the public to expect that the therapist will treat that information for the best use for the client. When, instead, that information is used by the therapist for the therapist's own needs, and is used beyond established boundaries, the conclusion of unprofessional conduct is manifest. Moreover, this case is particularly egregious since the allegations and proven facts are so similar to the facts for which the Respondent was previously disciplined approximately three years ago from the date of this hearing. The Vermont Administrative Rule for Allied Mental Health Practitioners, Rule 6.6, was clearly violated here, as was the case in the prior decision of 2023.

The Board finds that public health, safety, or welfare imperatively requires emergency suspension of Respondent's Licensed Mental Health Counselor License.

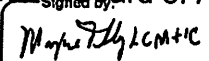
Order

The Request for Summary Suspension is **Granted**. Respondent's license is **Summarily Suspended** and shall not be subject renewal or reinstatement during the period of Summary Suspension without Board approval pending proceedings. These proceedings shall be promptly instituted and determined. 3 V.S.A. § 814(c).

Pursuant to 3 V.S.A. § 125(b)(11) and 3 V.S.A. § 129(a)(3), a Disciplinary Action Surcharge in the amount of two hundred and fifty dollars (\$250.00) is assessed against Respondent. Respondent shall remit payment within 180 days of the date of entry of this Order. Payment of the surcharge may be on a payment plan if needed. Failure to remit payment may result in the non-renewal of Respondent's license/credential.

SO ORDERED.

Vermont Board of Allied Mental Health Practitioners.

By: 
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Marjorie Trombly, Vice-Chair

Date: 8/26/2026, 2026

OFFICE OF PROFESSIONAL REGULATION

DATE OF ENTRY: 8/26/26

Appeal Procedure

This is an interlocutory order by the Office of Professional Regulation or by a Board within the Office. For information on appealing interlocutory orders, see Administrative Rule of Practice 4.7 (C.V.R. 04-030-005(4.7)).